The team went into mourning. By now I thought that I would not get another chance to push for the liquid engine. Not only that the test was a failure, the explosion had destroyed the test stand which then cost around Rs 2 lakh. The team asked what we should do. I asked them to pack up and get back to Trivandrum. I did not want to get back to Trivandrum, where my detractors waited gleefully. I went to the SHAR (Sriharitoka Range) guest house in Poes Garden, Chennai. The guest house, always open for us space scientists, had a few rooms. The manager asked me how many of us were there. I said I was alone. He said a room was available for me, but the other two rooms where occupied by Satish Dhawan and Brahm Prakash, then director of Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre.

Now I knew what to do. I grabbed the first piece of paper I could lay my hands on, wrote my resignation letter and walked into the room where Dhawan and Brahm Prakash were in a discussion. My face was roasted red from the long hours in the sun. I handed over the letter to Dhawan. He studied me for a moment, then asked what had happened. I explained that the test was a failure, and that I think I am incompetent to continue in the organisation.

'And, yes,' I added. 'I have caused a loss of about Rs 2 lakh by blasting the test stand.'

'But why the resignation?' Dhawan demanded.

By now I was fuming. I had great respect for Dhawan, but at this moment, I blew my fuse.

'These guys,' I said, referring to the large majority of scientists, engineers and administrators at VSSC who were trying to quell the liquid engine concept, 'are kicking me around like a football. And you people do nothing to support me. Enough is enough. I want to leave this organisation and do something else for a livelihood.'

Dhawan and Brahm Prakash remained silent through my twenty-minute outburst. Then Dhawan spoke something to the effect that I had misunderstood him. I realised that I had been harsh, but even now I was too hurt to mellow down.